Attending to Athletes' Health and Safety

From R. Rehberg, *Sport First Aid*, 6th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2026), 4-12.

The coach plays a central role in protecting the health and safety of an athlete. Every coach must understand the importance of excellent communication. Coaches (head and assistant) need to communicate with all parties (athletes, parents or guardians, other coaches and staff, and various members of the athletic health care team) involved in sport safety. Coaches should establish and monitor rules, policies, and procedures with athletes, parents or guardians, and athletic health care team members alike. For teams with multiple coaches, the head coach should assume the majority of the responsibilities. Assistant coaches should stand by to assist the head coach.

Coaches are responsible for knowing and understanding the rules of their specific sport as set forth by the governing body of the sport. Coaches must also know and understand the sport safety policies, protocols, and guidelines at their school or organization. Established policies, protocols, and guidelines guide the coach in working to ensure injury prevention, recognition, assessment, first aid, treatment, rehabilitation, and safe return to play. Examples include preparticipation physical examinations, emergency action plans, procedures for cardiac emergencies or concussion, education for injury prevention, guidelines for hydration, and procedures for extreme weather (heat, cold, or lightning).

The primary role of coaches is to minimize injury for athletes who are under their supervision. Therefore, as a coach, you are likely to be involved in each leg of the athletic health care relay—prevention, recognition and first aid care, assessment and treatment, and rehabilitation. Your role is defined by

- certain rules of the legal system and rules of your school administration,
- expectations of parents or guardians, and
- interactions with other athletic health care team members.

Minimizing the risk of injury to athletes encompasses a variety of coaching duties. As a coach, you should perform the following duties to safely train your athletes:

1. Properly plan each activity.
    - Teach the skills of the sport using the correct progression.
    - Consider each athlete's developmental level and current physical condition. Evaluate your athletes' physical capacities and skill levels with preseason fitness tests, and develop practice plans accordingly.

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- Keep written records of fitness test results and practice plans. Don't deviate from your plans without good cause.

2. Provide proper instruction.
   - Make sure that athletes are in proper condition to participate.
   - Teach athletes the rules and the correct skills and strategies of the sport. For example, in American football, teach athletes that tackling with the head (spearing) is illegal and potentially dangerous.
   - Teach athletes the sport skills and conditioning exercises in a progression so that they are adequately prepared to handle more difficult skills or exercises.
   - Stay current about more effective and safer ways of performing the techniques used in the sport.
   - Provide competent and responsible assistants. If you have coaching assistants, make sure that they are knowledgeable in the skills and strategies of the sport and that they behave in a mature and responsible manner.
3. Warn of inherent risks.
   - Provide parents or guardians and athletes with both oral and written statements of the inherent health risks of their particular sport.
   - Warn athletes about potentially harmful conditions, such as playing conditions, dangerous or faulty equipment, and the like.
4. Provide a safe physical environment.
   - Monitor current environmental conditions, such as windchill, temperature, humidity, and severe weather warnings.
   - Periodically inspect the playing areas, the locker room, the weight room, and the dugout for hazards.
   - Remove all hazards.
   - Prevent improper or unsupervised use of facilities.
5. Provide adequate and proper equipment.
   - Make sure athletes are using equipment that provides the maximum amount of protection against injury.
   - Inspect equipment regularly.
   - Teach athletes how to fit, use, and inspect their equipment.
6. Match your athletes appropriately.
   - Match the athletes according to size, physical maturity, skill level, and experience.
   - Do not pit physically immature or novice athletes against those who are in top condition and are highly skilled.
7. Evaluate athletes for injury or incapacity.
   - Require all athletes to participate in preseason physical exams, health screenings, and sport ability screenings to detect potential health problems and monitor performance.

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- If an athlete is unable to compete without pain or loss of function (e.g., inability to walk, run, jump, or throw without restriction), withhold that athlete from practice and competition.

8. Supervise each activity closely.
   - Do not allow athletes to practice difficult or potentially dangerous skills without proper supervision.
   - Forbid rough or boisterous play (e.g., wrestling around) during the activity.
   - Do not allow athletes to use sport facilities without supervision.
9. Provide appropriate emergency assistance.
   - Learn sport first aid as well as cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR) and use of an automated external defibrillator (AED). You can take a course through organizations such as the American Red Cross or the American Heart Association.
   - Take action when needed. As a coach, you are responsible for ensuring athletes under your supervision receive immediate care if they become ill or injured. If no medical personnel are present when an injury or illness occurs, you are responsible for providing emergency care.
   - Use only the skills that you are trained to administer, and provide the specific standard of care that you are trained to provide through sport first aid, CPR, and other sports medicine courses.
   - For athletes who are minors, obtain a signed consent form from their parents or guardians before the season begins. For injured or ill adult athletes, specifically ask if they want help. If they are unresponsive, consent is usually implied. If they refuse help and you believe they need medical care, send for emergency medical assistance or obtain assistance from a health care provider, such as an athletic trainer, if available. As a coach, you should become familiar with each of the nine duties described in this section. The first eight deal mainly with preventive measures. This book is primarily designed to help you handle duty number 9.

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SAFETY MEASURE

When to Return to Play

Athletes with any of the following conditions should not return to play until they have been evaluated by the appropriate health care professional:

- Inability to bear full weight with walking, jogging, or running
- Loss of function (upper or lower extremity)
- Any signs or symptoms from a head injury
- Fever
- Dehydration
- Any heat- or cold-related issue
- Any pain-related issue

Athlete's Role

Sports begin and end with the athlete. Athletes must understand the role they play in managing their own safety. Following rules, understanding guidelines and procedures, and advocating for their own well-being are cornerstones to the athletes' own safety. Their safety starts with following their school's or organization's preparticipation process.

Organizations should establish an education process for athletes, such as online education programs, informational pamphlets, or live or virtual lectures. These programs ensure that athletes are aware of signs and symptoms of foreseeable injuries or conditions and that they understand the importance of reporting these signs and symptoms to their parents or guardians, coaches, athletic trainers, or other pertinent staff members.

Parent's or Guardian's Role

Parents or guardians can assist the athletic health care team by ensuring that their child completes the school's or organization's preparticipation sport screening. They should educate themselves as a means of assisting their child in safe participation in sports, thereby allowing for better performance and reduction of injury.

To ensure continuity of communication, parents or guardians should be encouraged to participate in their child's safety. Parents or guardians should establish an open line of communication with their child, and they should watch for the signs and symptoms of injury and illness. This awareness is an important factor in protecting the long- and short-term athletic goals of the child. When parents or guardians support the decisions of

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sports medicine health care professionals in terms of play restrictions, limitations, and return to play, they help set their children up for success.

To help parents or guardians actively participate in athletes' safety, the coach or athletic health care team must communicate openly with them; they should keep parents or guardians informed of injury or illness situations arising with their child. In addition, the athletic health care team should expect to answer a variety of questions from parents or guardians, such as the following:

- What documents do I need to complete before practice starts?
- What protective equipment do I need to provide my athlete?
- What is the best way to contact you in the event of an emergency?
- What exactly is my child's injury?
- Can my child continue to play with this injury without making it worse?
- Does my child need to see a doctor?
- Is there anything I need to buy to be able to help my child compete (e.g., brace, pads, mouth guard)?
- If my child is unable to play now, when is it safe to return to the sport?
- Who determines when it is safe for my child to return to the sport?
- Is there any return to play progression my child needs to follow?
- How can this injury be prevented next time?

In summary, the role of parents and guardians on the athletic health care team entails actively staying informed about and involved in their child's safety. Coaches facilitate this role by communicating with them.

Roles of Other Members of the Athletic Health Care Team

While the head coach plays a central role on the athletic health care team, some peripheral team members have crucial supporting roles in ensuring the health and safety of athletes. This section describes these members, their roles, and the head coach's role in interacting with them.

Athletic Trainer

In many situations, the athletic trainer is the leader of the athletic health care team. The athletic trainer is most likely the first contact for the athlete with a medical concern. Oftentimes, the athletic trainer has already developed a rapport and relationship with the athletes. An athletic trainer (AT) is a health care professional trained in the prevention, emergency care, clinical diagnosis, therapeutic intervention, and

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rehabilitation of injuries and medical conditions. ATs collaborate with physicians to provide health care to the physically active. They observe for mechanisms of injury, and they can evaluate and treat injuries. Employing an AT helps to quickly determine an injury, decreases liability, and helps to rehabilitate the athlete after an injury. Having an AT on staff can facilitate a shorter recovery time for the athlete while also allowing the coaches to concentrate on coaching. An AT's ability to provide the proper physical medicine and rehabilitation techniques will provide the athlete with the environment that is most conducive to promoting healing and return to play. The AT can help to create demand-specific rehabilitation programs for athletes in a variety of sports and different positions within the sport.

Of course, prevention is the first domain for any AT. ATs are trained to prevent injury in various ways, including the following:

- Ensure proper fitting of equipment, padding, and bracing
- Ensure preventive and postinjury taping and strapping
- Assist with the administrative processes of medical and conditioning screening
- Perform field and facility inspections
- Monitor environmental factors
- Assist athletes on proper nutrition and hydration recommendations

Other functions of the AT may include the following:

- Athlete and coach education
- Injury assessment and documentation
- Emergency care
- Coordination of care
- Planning and training for emergencies during games and practices
- Communication with parents or guardians
- Injury rehabilitation
- Decisions for return to play

When an athlete has been injured, the coach's role is to work closely with the AT to provide information on how the injury occurred as well as to support the AT's decisions regarding the athlete's care, ability to participate, and compliance in a rehabilitation plan.

Physician

Physicians play an important role on the athletic health care team. They can evaluate and diagnose illnesses and injuries, prescribe appropriate care, and also prescribe treatment and rehabilitation for illness and injury. Physicians on the athletic health care team should

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- have a doctor of medicine (MD) or doctor of osteopathic medicine (DO) degree and be licensed in the state where they are practicing;
- possess fundamental knowledge of providing emergency care at sport events;
- be trained in CPR and AED; and
- have a working knowledge of trauma, musculoskeletal injury, and medical conditions affecting athletes.

In addition to the team physician, an injured or ill athlete may need to see other physicians for more specialized care. While the athlete's parents or legal guardians (or the athlete's insurance plan) may ultimately dictate the next step, the team physician can help you determine which type of physician the injured or ill athlete should see (e.g., a family practitioner, a pediatrician, an orthopedist, or a podiatrist). Types of physicians that may be involved in an athlete's care include the following:

- *Family practice and internal medicine physicians*—Specialize in general medicine.
- *Pediatricians*—Specialize in providing medical care to children from infants to teenagers.
- *Orthopedists*—Specialize in the diagnosis and treatment (which may include surgery) of injuries to the bones, ligaments, tendons, muscles, and joints.
- *Neurologists*—Specialize in the treatment of injuries to the nervous system and brain.
- *Physiatrists*—Specialize in physical medicine, including diagnosis, treatment, and rehabilitation.
- *Podiatrists*—Specialize in the medical care of foot and ankle problems.
- *Ophthalmologists*—Specialize in medicine related to proper management of eye-related issues.
- *Physician assistant*—A physician assistant (PA) is a licensed medical professional who holds an advanced degree and is able to provide direct patient care. The specific duties of a PA are determined by their supervising physician and state law, but they provide many of the same services as a primary care physician.
- *Nurse practitioner*—A nurse practitioner (NP) is a health care professional who offers a wide range of acute, primary, and specialty care services, either alone or alongside a doctor.

Once the team physician or other specialty physician has examined an athlete, the coach should support the physician's recommendations, including restrictions on sport participation. If a parent or legal guardian is not satisfied with the physician's diagnosis and treatment, seeking a second opinion may be warranted. However, it is unethical for a parent, guardian, or coach to send an injured or ill athlete to numerous physicians (often referred to as "doctor shopping") in an attempt to get permission for the athlete to resume activity.

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After the team physician or other specialty physician has evaluated an injured or ill athlete, the coach, along with the parents or guardians, should urge the athlete to obtain a referral from the physician and seek follow-up care with an AT (if one is not available through the school or organization) or physical therapist at a local sports medicine clinic, physical therapy clinic, or hospital physical therapy department. (The physical therapist's role is discussed in the next section.)

Physical Therapist

Physical therapists (PTs) are health professionals who rehabilitate individuals experiencing disease or injury. They are trained to handle a wide variety of medical problems, including cerebral palsy, strokes, heart problems, paraplegia, burns, and athletic injuries. Some PTs specialize in the evaluation, care, and rehabilitation of sport injuries.

These professionals are trained to analyze strength, joint motion, flexibility, coordination, and other physical attributes, and then instruct the athlete in an individualized rehabilitation program. They are also trained in administering modalities such as whirlpools, massage, ultrasound, and muscle stimulation as well as therapies such as joint mobilization. These modalities and therapies are important to help ease pain, decrease swelling, promote tissue healing, and restore function for a safe return to sport participation.

When an athlete has been injured, the coach's, athlete's, and parent's or guardian's roles in working with a PT are the same as working with an AT. The coach, the athlete, and the parent or guardian should provide information on how the injury occurred and support the PT's decisions regarding the athlete's care, ability to participate, and compliance in a rehabilitation plan.

Dentist or Oral Surgeon

Both dentists and oral surgeons are medically trained to evaluate and treat conditions and injuries of the mouth, jaw, and teeth. Oral surgeons have completed a hospital surgical residency program for further training in the surgical treatment of conditions affecting the mouth, teeth and jaw, and portions of the face.

Dentists and oral surgeons can provide assistance and recommendations to athletes on mouth guards and other equipment to protect the face and mouth. When an athlete participates in a contact sport, the coach and the parent or guardian should encourage the athlete to wear an appropriate protective mouthpiece or a face protector.

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Optometrist

Although they are not medical doctors, doctors of optometry (optometrists) receive specialized training and certification in diagnosing vision problems and eye disease. They are also trained to prescribe eyeglasses, contact lenses, and drugs to treat eye disorders. When an athlete participates in a contact sport, the coach and the parent or guardian should encourage the athlete to use appropriate protective eyewear or a face protector.

Emergency Medical Technician (EMT) and Paramedic

Emergency medical technicians (EMTs) and paramedics are trained to provide emergency medical care for a variety of situations and conditions. They are also experts in immobilizing serious injuries and providing rapid response and transportation to the appropriate emergency medical facility.

Use the following guidelines for situations when emergency medical services are needed:

- Communicate with the athletic health care team in advance, and practice emergency scenarios together.
- Have emergency contact information ready, such as parent or guardian information, medical allergies and conditions, and other pertinent information, to give to EMTs and paramedics.
- Be ready to assist in crowd control. Some people who are not needed in the situation may hinder the emergency response. It is very important that only the necessary personnel be involved in the situation.
- Have an area designated for quick access to and from your facility.
- Document the injury, event, and any first aid performed prior to the emergency team's arrival.

EMTs and paramedics are unique in that they are members of the athletic health care team who do not already know your athletes. Therefore, clear communication about your athletes' health is crucial.

Strength and Conditioning Coach

The strength and conditioning coach can perform fitness assessments and develop and supervise the proper strength and conditioning needs of the athletes. Quality strength and conditioning coaches may have certifications from accredited organizations such as the National Strength and Conditioning Association (NSCA) or the American College of Sports Medicine (ACSM). The strength and conditioning coach works with athletes, coaches, and parents or guardians with a focus on these three goals: improve athletic performance; reduce athletic injuries; and teach lifelong fitness and movement skills (strengthen, stretch). The head coach should insist that athletes attend fitness

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assessments and participate in all conditioning workouts with the strength and conditioning coach.

Equipment Manager

Some schools or organizations may assign someone to the role of equipment manager. This person should be tasked with the fitting, inspection, cleaning, maintenance, and storage of equipment. In cases when standards are in place for equipment, the equipment manager must know the standards and abide by the regulations for the equipment. For example, the equipment manager is expected to know standards for various types of helmets and adhere to rules regarding their shelf life.

In working with the equipment manager, the coach's role is to assist as needed with equipment fitting and maintenance and to enforce athletes' proper use of equipment. The coach should also help watch for equipment wear and tear. Athletes and parents or guardians can also pay attention to these details when equipment is taken home.

Conclusion

The importance of the athletic health care team can't be understated. Team members must all understand their roles and work within those roles. Team members should feel confident in their own abilities and in the abilities of the other team members. Organization and communication are essential components of the success of the athletic health care team. Table 1.1 summarizes the goals and common roles of each member of the athletic health care team.

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Table 1.1 *Athletic Health Care Team Goals and Roles*

	GOALS OF THE ATHLETIC HEALTH CARE TEAM			
	Injury prevention	**Injury recognition and initial first aid care**	**Injury assessment and initial treatment**	**Follow-up care**
Coach	• Ensure athlete receives preseason screening and physical exam. • Ensure athlete participates in conditioning programs. • Ensure athlete wears appropriate protective equipment. • Enforce safety rules.	• Watch for injuries and illnesses. • Act as first responder in providing first aid assessment and care. • Recommend athlete's injury or illness be thoroughly evaluated and properly treated.	• Act as first responder in providing first aid care.	• Encourage athlete to exactly follow rehabilitation and conditioning instructions. • Don't allow athlete to participate until given clearance.
Athlete	• Receive preseason screening and physical exam. • Participate in conditioning programs. • Wear appropriate protective equipment. • Abide by safety rules.	• Inform parent or guardian, coach, or athletic trainer of illness or injury. • Receive injury or illness assessment by physician, athletic trainer, or physical therapist.	• Receive first aid care or physician treatment.	• Perform rehabilitation and conditioning exercises exactly as instructed. • Return to activities only after given clearance.
Parent or guardian	• Ensure athlete receives preseason screening and physical exam. • Ensure athlete participates in conditioning programs. • Ensure athlete wears appropriate protective equipment.	• Watch for injuries and illnesses. • Ensure athlete's injury or illness is thoroughly evaluated and properly treated.	• Ensure athlete receives appropriate first aid or physician treatment.	• Encourage athlete to exactly follow rehabilitation and conditioning instructions. • Don't allow athlete to participate until given clearance.

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	GOALS OF THE ATHLETIC HEALTH CARE TEAM *(continued)*			
Athletic trainer	• Provide preseason fitness and injury risk assessment screening. • Assist with scheduling and conducting preseason physical exams. • Recommend or develop conditioning programs. • Inspect condition of equipment and playing areas. • Recommend replacing or refurbishing faulty equipment or playing areas. • Ensure proper equipment fitting for each athlete. • Recommend preventive bracing or taping as needed.	• Watch for injuries and illnesses. • Provide emergency medical care. • Assist EMTs or paramedics in preparing an athlete for transportation to a medical facility. • Recommend physician diagnosis as needed.	• Provide injury treatments (such as ultrasound) as prescribed by a physician.	• Assess athlete's symptoms and ability to function. • Develop individualized rehabilitation program. • Maintain athlete's fitness during rehabilitation. • Safely progress athlete back into full activity. • Develop and fit protective braces or pads to prevent reinjury.
Physician	• Conduct preseason physical exams.	• Volunteer or contract to provide on-site emergency medical assistance at sport events. • Evaluate athlete by conducting or ordering appropriate diagnostic tests.	• Prescribe appropriate treatment. • Refer injured athlete to athletic trainer or physical therapist for rehabilitation.	• May recommend or prescribe specific rehabilitation exercises. • May provide final clearance for return to full participation.

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	GOALS OF THE ATHLETIC HEALTH CARE TEAM *(continued)*			
Physical therapist	• Provide preseason fitness and injury risk assessment screening. • Recommend preventive bracing or taping as needed.	• Watch for injuries and illnesses. • Act as first responder in providing first aid assessment and care. • Recommend physician diagnosis as needed.	• Provide injury treatments (such as ultrasound) as prescribed by a physician.	• Assess athlete's symptoms and ability to function. • Develop individualized rehabilitation program. • Maintain athlete's fitness during rehabilitation. • Safely progress athlete back into full activity. • Develop and fit protective braces or pads to prevent reinjury.
Dentist or oral surgeon	• Recommend and fit mouth guards.	• Evaluate dental injuries.	• Treat dental injuries.	• Provide final clearance for return to full activity after dental injury.
Optometrist	• Recommend and fit appropriate protective eyewear.	N/A	N/A	• Assist with follow-up care of eye injuries when needed.
Emergency medical technician and paramedic	N/A	• Volunteer or contract to provide on-site emergency medical assessment, care, and transportation at sport events.	• Provide advanced emergency medical care.	• Transport via ambulance as needed.

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	GOALS OF THE ATHLETIC HEALTH CARE TEAM *(continued)*			
Strength and conditioning coach	• Provide preseason fitness screening. • Develop and supervise conditioning programs.	• Watch for injuries and illnesses. • Act as first responder in providing first aid assessment and care. • Recommend athlete's injury or illness be thoroughly evaluated and properly treated. • Do not allow athlete to participate until given clearance.	• Act as first responder in providing first aid care.	• Encourage athlete to exactly follow rehabilitation and conditioning instructions.
Equipment manager	• Inspect condition of equipment. • Replace or oversee refurbishing of faulty equipment. • Ensure proper equipment fitting for each athlete.	N/A	N/A	• Check equipment for damage or other issues.

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